xvii, banned "any corporation whatever" from making "a money contribution in connection with" federal elections, 34 Stat. 864–865.

Since 1907, there has been continual congressional attention to corporate political activity, sometimes resulting in refinement of the law, sometimes in overhaul.[3] One feature, however, has stayed intact throughout this "careful legislative adjustment of the federal electoral laws," *National Right to Work*, *supra*, at 209, and much of the periodic amendment was meant to strengthen the original, core prohibition on direct corporate contributions. The Foreign Corrupt Practices Act of 1925, for example, broadened the ban on contributions to include "anything of value," and criminalized the act of receiving a contribution to match the criminality of making one. Ch. 368, §§302, 313, 43 Stat. 1070, 1074. So, in another instance, the 1947 Labor Management Relations Act drew labor unions permanently within the law's reach and invigorated the earlier prohibition to include "expenditure[s]" as well. Ch. 120, §304, 61 Stat. 159; see *Pipefitters*, *supra*, at 402.

Today, as in 1907, the law focuses on the "special characteristics of the corporate structure" that threaten the integrity of the political process. *National Right to Work*, 459 U. S., at 209; see *id.*, at 207; see also *Austin* v. *Michigan Chamber of Commerce*, 494 U. S. 652, 658–659 (1990); *Massachusetts Citizens for Life*, 479 U. S., at 257–258; *Federal Election Comm'n* v. *National Conservative Political Action Comm.*, 470 U. S. 480, 500–501 (1985). As we explained it in *Austin*,

[3] See, *e. g.*, Act of June 25, 1910, ch. 392, 36 Stat. 822; Act of Aug. 19, 1911, ch. 33, 37 Stat. 25; Federal Corrupt Practices Act, 1925, ch. 368, 43 Stat. 1070; Act of July 19, 1940 (Hatch Act), 54 Stat. 767; War Labor Disputes Act, 1943, ch. 144, §9, 57 Stat. 167; Labor Management Relations Act, 1947, §304, 61 Stat. 159; Act of Oct. 31, 1951, §21, 65 Stat. 718; Federal Election Campaign Act of 1971 (FECA), 86 Stat. 3; FECA Amendments of 1974, 88 Stat. 1263; FECA Amendments of 1976, 90 Stat. 475; FECA Amendments of 1979, 93 Stat. 1339; Bipartisan Campaign Reform Act of 2002, 116 Stat. 81.

> "State law grants corporations special advantages—such as limited liability, perpetual life, and favorable treatment of the accumulation and distribution of assets—that enhance their ability to attract capital and to deploy their resources in ways that maximize the return on their shareholders' investments. These state-created advantages not only allow corporations to play a dominant role in the Nation's economy, but also permit them to use 'resources amassed in the economic marketplace' to obtain 'an unfair advantage in the political marketplace.'" 494 U. S., at 658–659 (quoting *Massachusetts Citizens for Life*, *supra*, at 257).

Hence, the public interest in "restrict[ing] the influence of political war chests funneled through the corporate form." *National Conservative Political Action Comm.*, *supra*, at 500–501; see *National Right to Work*, *supra*, at 207 ("[S]ubstantial aggregations of wealth amassed by the special advantages which go with the corporate form of organization should not be converted into political 'war chests' which could be used to incur political debts from legislators").

As these excerpts from recent opinions show, not only has the original ban on direct corporate contributions endured, but so have the original rationales for the law. In barring corporate earnings from conversion into political "war chests," the ban was and is intended to "preven[t] corruption or the appearance of corruption." *National Conservative Political Action Comm.*, *supra*, at 496–497; see also *First Nat. Bank of Boston* v. *Bellotti*, 435 U. S. 765, 788, n. 26 (1978) ("The importance of the governmental interest in preventing [corruption] has never been doubted"). But the ban has always done further duty in protecting "the individuals who have paid money into a corporation or union for purposes other than the support of candidates from having that money used to support political candidates to whom they may be opposed." *National Right to Work*, *supra*, at 208;